



Gold restored: Final of the men's 100m at the 1988 Seoul Olympics — a race that shook the world. Ben Johnson crossed first, but after his steroid scandal, Carl Lewis (fourth from left) was crowned champion, with Linford Christie and Calvin Smith moving up the podium. GETTY IMAGES

run the turn right,' and 'You fouled too many times.' So I worked on those things.

Is that the kind of obsession needed to be great?

Everyone has their own way, but I was in a unique situation because I did both the jumps and the sprints. In the 30 years since I retired, maybe only a couple of athletes have had success in both. There aren't many people who've been in my situation.

I also don't think we'll see it happen again. That's just how society is now. You won't see another Jesse Owens, someone excelling in both the sprints and the jumps. I just don't see it.

It was different for me because I had to do so much more than everyone else in the competition. I

was always doing two events a day, so I had to look at things differently.

Why do you think athletes these days don't combine events?

Honestly, the long jump is too difficult for most people. They just give up on it. It's not that there isn't talent — there are plenty of great athletes who could do it. But when they reach the next level, they realise, "Man, the sprints are pretty easy compared to that jump."

I was always a jumper at heart. I loved the event because it was hard. To me, the sprints were the easier part. Since I already enjoyed doing the tougher thing, it allowed me to do both.

I don't think too many fans would have guessed that. What do you

think a lot of fans miss about track and field?

The technical aspect, for sure. When it comes to sprinting, most people can only run at full speed for about one second — so for most of the race, you're either speeding up or slowing down.

Many people would tell me, 'You didn't get a good start.' And I'd think, no, I had exactly the start I trained to have. I knew that 90 per cent of my race was designed a certain way, and that start was part of the design.

Why do you think jumpers aren't hitting the same distances as in your generation?

One thing I'm noticing is that jumpers today aren't having the same kind of success we did. I think they're jumping differently, and that's why they're struggling. I see certain things they're not doing if they want to go farther.

There are crucial movements in the final three steps of a long jump — small but vital changes in the angle of take-off that allow you to hit the board with more force and speed. It's a little complicated, but that's where the distance comes from.

Right now, most long jumpers are in the 8.40m or maybe 8.50m range. That's solid; they're good athletes, and they're working hard. But if you want to jump 8.60m, 8.70m, 8.80m or even 8.90m, there are specific things you need to do differently, and I'm not seeing that.

It's the same on the women's side. They're jumping around 7.00m, but if you want to reach 7.30m or 7.40m, there's something different you have to work on.

I understand what needs to be done, but right now we're in a space where it's acceptable to jump 8.40m as long as you get the medal. And, yes, it's the same Olympic medal I received — I jumped 8.72m in Seoul — but performance is about more than the prize. It's about you.

It's not that today's athletes aren't good. The long jump is just an event that works against your instincts. You have to fight genetics and fight what your body is telling you not to do to perform it correctly. We're not